on either side, and a thousand balls came whizzing and whistling about our heads. The hills were lined with the enemy, and they began a most heavy fire.'[76] Among those who had a narrow escape at this point was Dr Brydon, who had resumed his duties as a regimental surgeon. 'He was sitting on a pole by which a dooly is carried, when a six pound shot from one of the enemy's guns struck and splintered the bamboo, but without injuring him in the least.'[77]

Unlike the last time Brydon had been in the pass, with his colleagues stumbling snow-blind and unresisting to their slaughter, this time Pollock's troops were ready. Abbott opened up with his guns and at the same time 'Sir Robert [Sale] gave the word for the 13th [Regiment] to ascend and storm the heights on the right, and the 9th and 31st those on the left,' remembered Greenwood.

> Up we went, helter skelter. The hill was very high and precipitous, and not easily ascended at any time; the shot of the enemy, however, quickened our motions, and in a short time we were up and at them. The fire was tremendous; the bullets were hopping and whistling among us in every direction. The enemy were very numerous, and seemed disposed to fight to the last for possession of the heights. No sooner, however, had our men arrived at the top than they fixed bayonets, and with a loud hurrah they charged the enemy . . . The Afghans were shouting their war cry of 'Allah il Ullah' and reproaching us with various elegant names, such as dogs, kafirs and the like, and assuring us we would never reach Kabul. Captain Broadfoot's sappers in particular gave as good as they got, in right good Billingsgate.[78]

Once the Afghans had been dislodged from their position, Sale kept his men driving them along the heights of the ridge, from peak to peak. Down below, meanwhile, the cavalry were charging Akbar's cannon, all of which had been captured from Elphinstone's force and were now manned by renegade Company sepoys who had taken their chances with Akbar Khan; as the cavalry closed in, the unfortunate Hindustani deserters were immediately 'put to the sword'.[79] The fighting went on all day, with the Afghans resisting with great bravery and refusing to yield an inch until driven off each successive peak with bayonets. By late afternoon, however, the hilltops had all been captured and Akbar Khan's men had no option but to turn and flee, with their leader and the Ghilzai chiefs doggedly bringing up the rear. So complete was the defeat that the following day the British passed along the even steeper heights of the Khord Kabul without having to fire a shot.